INDIAN STUDENTS STUDYING IN JAPAN

Japan and India have enjoyed long-standing cultural exchanges for more than a millennium starting from the arrival of Buddhism in Japan in the 6th century. Based on the lasting tradition of mutual respect and understanding, our relations have continued to flourish. Today, the relationship has grown into a Special Strategic and Global Partnership. Our partnership is based on a deep respect for each other's contribution toward promoting peace, stability and development in Asia and beyond.

This year is a really special year for both countries. As we celebrate the 70th anniversary of our diplomatic ties, Prime Minister Kishida visited India in March, and Prime Minister Modi visited Japan in May. Realization of these reciprocal visits really helped to solidify our ties. For example, one of the major outcomes of the Japan-India Summit Meeting in March was the announcement made by our two leaders, setting a target of 5 trillion yen (3.4 trillion rupees) of public and private investment and financing from Japan to India in the next five years. Japan, being the largest contributor of official development assistance to India, is truly an important partner for India's development. From huge infrastructure projects like the Mumbai-Ahmedabad Bullet Train to the health sector, Japan is a trusted friend that always stands with India in its efforts to achieve a better future for its people.

Is it not important then, for the two countries to have more people-to-people exchanges? The answer is "yes". In fact, the two leaders reaffirmed their resolve to make our partnership more robust and complementary through people-to-people exchanges when they met in March. However, the number of Indians studying in Japan in 2019 stood at a meager 1850. This when the number of foreign students studying in Japan was approximately 3.1 Lak in the same year, with many students from various countries around the world coming to Japan to stay. India is the second largest exporter of international students in the world according to UNESCO statistics, with more than 4.6 Lak Indian students studying abroad in 2019. Why then, is only a small number of them going to Japan to study?

We think this gap is because Indian students are not fully aware of the appeal of studying in Japan, nor do they know enough about how to access information about it. The more you know about Japan and the merit of studying in Japan, the more you will want to study in Japan.

THE ATTRACTION OF STUDYING IN JAPAN

How do Indian students decide where to study? There are many factors: cost, quality of education, environment, language, and many more. Studying in Japan can provide Indian students with a wonderful environment and various experiences.

It is precise because of the advanced knowledge and technology fostered by its excellent educational system that Japan, with its limited resources, has achieved economic growth, becoming a manufacturing powerhouse. Using cutting-edge science, technology, and medicine, Japan has introduced many products to the world. Turning innovative ideas into creative products is deeply engraved in Japan's history. Japanese schools focus not only on academic achievement but also on developing human qualities. International students highly appreciate that their studies in Japan will help them when they enter the workforce.

And Japan is an island nation surrounded by the sea and with few flatlands and many mountains. The climate is temperate, but the four seasons are distinct, allowing people to enjoy a variety of seasons. There are food ingredients produced from abundant nature and various cuisines using them. With a healthy diet and advanced medical technology, as well as a universal health insurance system, Japan is known as the country with the longest life expectancy in the world.

In addition to about 800 universities, the Japanese higher education system includes "Junior Colleges", "Colleges of Technology" and "Specialized Training Colleges". There are about 4500 institutions in total. Japanese universities and junior colleges in Japan accept international students in around 15,400 undergraduate and postgraduate courses and around 1,560 university undergraduate, master's and doctoral courses use English as their primary language of instruction.

Japan's universities are globally competitive. 38 Japanese universities ranked in the top 1,000 of the QS World University Rankings, as of June 2022. The number of Novel Prize winners is 27, which is No. 1 in Asia. And each Japanese school offers a good educational environment for students since the minimum standards for schools are set by the government, such as the ratio of professors and teachers to students, the size of facilities, and the kind of facilities to be established. Japanese schools offer Indian students high quality education as many schools have educational environments that go well beyond those standards

The cost of research and studying in Japan is relatively low compared to other countries, like the United States, the United Kingdom, and Singapore. Various institutions and organizations, including the Japanese Government, offer scholarships, and many universities also offer tuition fee reductions and exemptions and housing assistance.

Safety is probably the most important factor in deciding where to study. International students want to avoid getting into trouble or falling victim to a crime in an unfamiliar place. As you know, Japan has a low crime rate and is one of the safest countries in the world. And Japan's convenient lifestyle and advanced medical services are backed up by one of the highest levels of science and technology in the world. International students not only feel safe and secure, but also enjoy a high quality and comfortable life and can also concentrate on their studies and research.

Since Japan and India have very different lifestyles and cultures, we know some people are concerned about cultural differences. Indian students studying in Japan need to be careful about food culture. Since there are not many vegetarians in Japan and there are no religiously forbidden foods, foods are not clearly labeled as they are in India. Since Japanese universities are accepting numerous foreign students from all over the world these days, please be assured that at least at universities, various considerations are made with regard to food culture.

However realizing these differences is one of the best parts of studying in Japan, and we believe that this experience will help you grow a lot. Japanese universities also provide various kinds of support to take care of international students, such as events for international students to learn more about Japan and opportunities to interact with Japanese people.

